The Silent Burdens (Gender Inequality, Patriarchy, and Sexism in Korea)

Tierra Parham · 2026

Kim Ji-Young: Born 1982 is a South Korean drama film that illustrates the sexism and inequality that women face in their everyday lives and the workplaces. The mistreatment and discrimination of women due to Korea's high-context culture, social norms, and predestined gender roles has been an issue for many years. There are several representations of social issue concepts within the film, but three scenes in particular will be discussed. Korean culture is family-centered and holds loved ones at high importance.

Towards the beginning, to celebrate the New Year, Ji-Young and her husband, Dae-Hyun, visit her in-laws' home with their daughter (Time Stamp: 5:53-12:23). It is there that one of the major social issues in Korean society is illustrated, the mistreatment of the daughter-in law. In accordance with Korean social norms, it is expected for a daughter in-law to wait on her husband and parents in-law hand in foot, always acting with respect and care and putting their well-being before her own. During this visit to Dae-Hyun's parents' home, Ji-Young is expected to cook a large amount of food for the family to enjoy for the holidays, wash the dishes, and serve food and drinks. Just when Ji-Young is about to finish her duties, Dae-Hyun's sister enters the home with her husband and sons. She mentions that she had a tough time at her in-laws' home before coming to see her parents, so Dae-Hyun's mother requests for Ji-Young to bring food and dessert for her daughter. This causes Ji-Young to experience a post-partum depressive episode, embodying her mother and expressing her discontentment with having to stay at Dae-Hyun's

family home and serve them without having the chance to visit her family. The same caregiving actions are not expected of a daughter in-law in America, but they are appreciated. In American society, the concept of a "good daughter-in-law" encompasses the qualities of respect and love towards her husband and in-law family. Given the widespread social dynamics and the desire for familial approval, a daughter-in-law often offers her assistance to any task she can undertake, but it may feel less burdensome. With respect, the importance of family, and social harmony being major Korean cultural values, Ji-Young attempted to speak politely to her in-laws while suppressing her emotions and frustrations, but these values can normalize and shield inequality.

Throughout the entirety of the film, Ji-Young appears visibly fatigued and depleted. However, there are instances when it appears that Ji-Young possesses a glimmer of hope and determination, particularly during her pursuit of her career (Time Stamp: 22:09-27:57). Ji-Young is an exceptional employee that does great work but when the opportunity for a promotion arose, she applied for it, but she did not receive the position. Later, the company Chief calls her to her office to praise her for her good work, leading Ji-Young to express that she believed the Chief did not like her because she was not chosen for the promotion. However, the reason lies within another common social issue in Korea, sexism and structural gender discrimination. In reality, the company made the decision to promote only men because a long-term team of over five years was intended. It was assumed that with marriage and parenting, it would be challenging for female workers. Although Ji-Young had not yet been married or had a child, due to normality of such situations and the predetermined future of all women, it was expected that Ji-Young would face the same fate and would not be capable of fulfilling the role on the promotion team. In the United States, an unintentional assumption that a man might be better for a role may be made by higher-ups in a company, but a woman's personal life generally does not play a part in the

decision making process. News of a female employee getting married or having a child does not undermine her work abilities or determine the time she has left in her position with the company. Typically, these milestones are celebrated, and the time needed to take care of personal matters is respected, but it does not bring discrimination upon female employees.

A major factor that shapes an individual's personality, values, insecurities, emotional triggers, and other aspects of their development is their parental influence and family dynamics in their youth. Ji-Young has one older sister and one younger brother, who were all treated the same by their mother, but not their father. Son preference, referring to a deeply rooted global phenomenon where parents value male children more than female children, is evident in Korea and has led to many challenges. This concept is driven by cultural, economic, and social factors. After discovering that Ji-Young is struggling with post-partum depression, her mother is distraught (Time Stamp: 1:25:36-1:27:58). She lies in bed, unable to speak despite her children's attempt to ask what is bothering her. At this time, Ji-Young's father returns home with a huge box of medicine. Ji-Young's siblings, currently worried about their mother who does not seem to be well, asks if the medicine is for the mother. Her father firmly declines and says the medicine is for Ji-Young's brother, stating "men should have good stuff like this". Hearing this infuriates Ji-Young's mother, so she finally confronts her father. She asks him how he can call himself a father if he only cares for his son and does not think to buy medicine for his daughters' health as well. She also mentions that it is because Ji-Young grew up like this (surrounded by toxic ideology and unequal treatment), that she became sick. It is plausible that in witnessing her brother's preferential treatment, Ji-Young learned that her needs and happiness are secondary. Son preference has historically existed in the United States but has declined greatly. While both Korean and American societies are shaped by gender expectations, in some American contexts

boys may receive less nurturing due to norms that emphasize toughness, independence, and emotional restraint. Nevertheless, both societies construct gender roles in distinct yet impactful ways.